Japan Trip FAQ (RAG Knowledge Base)

This document is a comprehensive FAQ for the Japan Trip. It has been formatted and optimized to ensure each Q&A item provides self-contained context for optimal RAG (Retrieval-Augmented Generation) performance.

1. Eligibility & Guests

Q: Can non-FTMBA (1st-year Full-Time MBA) students participate in the Japan Trip?

A: Yes, the Japan Trip is open to all UCLA Anderson students. Every year, a significant number of second-year students and students from non-FTMBA programs join the trip.

Q: Can I bring my spouse or partner (Significant Other)?

A: Yes, each registered MBA student is allowed to register one Significant Other (SO). The participation fee for an SO is the same as that for an MBA student.

Q: Can I bring more than one Significant Other or additional guests?

A: If there are remaining spots after the application deadline, we may be able to accommodate additional guests. Please contact the organizing team directly if you wish to bring more than one guest.

Q: Can I bring a friend who is not affiliated with Anderson or an alumnus/alumna?

A: No, unfortunately not. The Japan Trip is strictly restricted to current Anderson students and their registered Significant Others. It is not open to alumni or outside non-Anderson guests.

2. Schedule, Partial Attendance & Free Time

Q: Is it possible to join late or leave early during the Japan Trip?

A: Yes, joining late or leaving early is allowed. However, please note that the full participation fee still applies regardless of your arrival or departure dates.

Q: Can I skip the Trip itself and only attend a few selected events?

A: No, partial attendance is not permitted. To ensure fairness for all participants, you must pay the full participation fee even if you only attend a portion of the scheduled events.

Q: Is participation in all scheduled events mandatory? Can I act separately?

A: We generally encourage all participants to attend all scheduled activities. If you choose to make separate plans or skip activities, those portion fees will not be refunded or waived, and you do so at your own risk.

Q: How much free time is scheduled during the Trip?

A: Free time is allocated on the following days:

- **Day 1:** Arrival Day (Kyoto)
- **Day 3:** Full Day (Kyoto)
- **Day 6:** Full Day (Tokyo)
- **Day 7:** Morning through Evening (Tokyo)
- **Day 8:** Departure Day / Check-out (Tokyo)

Q: What optional tours will be available?

A: We are currently planning optional tours in Kyoto (Day 3) and Tokyo (Days 6–7). Specific details will be announced as soon as they are finalized.

Q: What is the schedule for Day 1 (March 21, Trip Start Day)?

A: There are no official events scheduled on March 21. You only need to arrive in Japan, travel to Kyoto, and check into the hotel. The remainder of the day is yours to enjoy as free time.

Q: Can I join the Trip on the morning of March 22 instead of March 21?

A: Our chartered bus leaves the hotel at 9:30 AM on March 22. Therefore, we strongly recommend arriving in Kyoto and checking into the hotel on the previous day (March 21).

Q: What is the schedule for Day 8 (March 27, Trip End Day)?

A: There are no official activities scheduled on March 27. You will only need to check out of the hotel, allowing you to leave at whatever time fits your personal travel schedule.

3. Flights, Transportation & Access

Q: When do core final exams end, and when does the spring quarter start for FTMBA?

A: For FTMBA students, core final exams run through March 18, and spring quarter instruction begins on March 29.

Q: Are there recommended flight schedules or arrival/departure times?

A: Because FTMBA core final exams conclude on Thursday, March 18, we recommend departing from LAX on March 18 or 19 and arriving in Kyoto (via KIX/ITM) on Saturday, March 20. For the return journey, you can schedule flights out of Japan starting Saturday, March 27. Please be cautious with flights departing LAX in the afternoon of March 19, as the time difference may cause you to arrive too late.

Q: What is the best route to travel from Los Angeles (LAX) to Kyoto?

A: Kansai International Airport (KIX) is the closest major international airport to Kyoto, from which you can take a direct train or bus. Alternatively, if you fly into Tokyo airports (Haneda/HND or Narita/NRT), you can take a domestic connection to Osaka Itami Airport (ITM) or travel via the Shinkansen (Bullet Train) from Shinagawa Station to Kyoto. ZIPAIR, a low-cost carrier operated by Japan Airlines flying between LAX and NRT, may offer the most economical fares.

Q: Should I book my flight right now?

A: Your spot on the Trip is only officially confirmed after registration opens at the Info Session and your deposit payment is processed. We recommend booking your flights after confirmation. If you are comfortable with the risk of being placed on a waitlist, you may book earlier.

Q: Are seats on the Shinkansen (Bullet Train) pre-assigned or individually selectable?

A: We reserve a block of seats for the group, so individual seat selection in advance is not possible. Upon boarding, please take any available seat within our designated reserved block. Note that the group may be split across two separate Shinkansen trains.

4. Accommodations, Roommate Selection & Facilities

Q: What room arrangements are included, and what options exist for single or 2-person rooms?

A: The base participation fee includes standard two-person rooms in Kyoto and Tokyo, and shared Japanese-style rooms (for 4–5 people) in Hiroshima. Upgrades to a two-person room in Hiroshima or a single room for the entire duration are available for an additional fee, subject to hotel availability.

Q: Can I request a single room or a Hiroshima two-person room option after the deadline?

A: Requests made after the December 4 deadline require individual verification with the hotel. Availability cannot be guaranteed, and prices may be higher than initial rates.

Q: How are roommates assigned? Can I choose my roommate?

A: If you are traveling with a Significant Other, you will automatically share a room with them. For other arrangements, preference surveys will be sent out around February, and we will do our best to pair you with your requested roommates. If opting for the 2-person Hiroshima room, please specify your roommate during application.

Q: Are smoking rooms available in the hotels?

A: No. All rooms booked for the Trip are strictly non-smoking.

Q: Is daily breakfast included with the hotel stays?

A: Breakfast is included only on Day 5 at the hotel in Hiroshima. On all other days, breakfast is not included.

Q: Are there restrictions on using the hotel Onsen (hot springs) for guests with tattoos?

A: Guests with tattoos are traditionally not permitted in public Onsen baths in Japan. In practice, modest tattoos are generally acceptable as long as you do not disturb other guests, or you may cover them with waterproof stickers. Please note that we plan to reserve the hotel Onsen in Hiroshima exclusively for our group, so tattoos will not be an issue there.

5. Meals, Dietary Restrictions & Social Events

Q: Are official parties or night events planned during the Trip?

A: Official group parties are scheduled for Day 2 (March 21 in Kyoto), Day 4 (March 23 in Hiroshima), and Day 7 (March 26 in Tokyo). Additionally, participants historically organize voluntary bar and club outings on other nights.

Q: Can dietary requirements such as vegetarian, vegan, or food allergies be accommodated?

A: Yes. For official meals included in the Trip program, dietary preferences such as meat-free, seafood-free, and vegan options can be accommodated. You will be able to submit your specific dietary restrictions during the application process.

Q: Are certified Halal meals provided?

A: While we can request meat-free options, we cannot guarantee that meals will be officially Halal-certified. If strict Halal food is required, please contact the organizing team directly prior to the event.

Q: Will restaurant recommendations be provided for free-time dining?

A: Yes, the organizing team will compile and share a curated list of recommended local restaurants near the hotels prior to the start of the Trip.

6. Expenses, Logistics & Rules

Q: What items are NOT included in the participation fee?

A: Airfare, optional travel insurance, and personal meals during free time are not included. *(Included items: Lodging, local group transportation, sightseeing entry fees, and official group parties.)*

Q: How much additional pocket money should I budget for personal expenses?

A: We recommend budgeting approximately $500 USD to cover personal meals, local transit during free time, and incidental expenses.

Q: What are the estimated flight costs from Los Angeles?

A: As of October 11 estimates: Connecting flights start around $1,000 USD, and direct non-stop flights start around $1,100 USD.

Q: What are the policies regarding public alcohol consumption and smoking in Japan?

A: Drinking alcohol in public open spaces (such as public streets or parks) is discouraged or restricted in many municipalities. Please restrict drinking to restaurants, official venues, or private spaces. Smoking (both tobacco and e-cigarettes) is strictly prohibited both indoors and outdoors throughout Japan, except within designated "Smoking Areas."

Q: What happens if applications exceed the total capacity?

A: Registration is processed on a first-come, first-served basis up to a total capacity of 80 participants. Once capacity is reached, additional applicants will be placed on a waitlist while organizers attempt to secure extra hotel room blocks.

Q: Is it possible to transfer or sell my participation ticket to another student?

A: Yes, you can transfer or resell your participation ticket through the registration system until February 12. Detailed instructions will be sent out after registration concludes.

Q: Are there luggage restrictions or luggage delivery services available?

A: There is no strict limit on luggage size or quantity. A luggage delivery service (Takkyubin) will be arranged to transport main luggage directly from Kyoto to Tokyo on Day 4. Please note

that bringing illegal substances—including cannabis in any form—into Japan is strictly prohibited by law.

Q: What credit card brands are accepted in Japan, and should I carry cash?

A: Visa and Mastercard are universally accepted at most establishments. However, some traditional restaurants and small shops remain cash-only. We recommend bringing around ¥10,000 JPY (approx. $60 USD) in cash.

Q: What kind of weather and clothing should I expect?

A: Average spring temperatures across the destinations:

- **Tokyo:** 41°F–57°F (Avg: 50°F) / 5°C–14°C
- **Kyoto:** 40°F–57°F (Avg: 49°F) / 4°C–14°C
- **Hiroshima:** 41°F–58°F (Avg: 49°F) / 5°C–14°C

Suggested Attire: Layered clothing such as a shirt with a sweater and light coat, or a sweatshirt with a jacket.

Q: Do I need a local SIM card or mobile data plan?

A: Since there are extended periods of free time and self-guided exploration, we strongly recommend purchasing a traveler eSIM or mobile data plan before or upon arrival in Japan.